

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 1 (Teaching Week 2): Is this politics?

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Is *this* politics?

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Which of these is politics?

- **The rent freeze.** A government caps what landlords can charge. Confiscation, or the only thing standing between her and the street?
- **The family row.** Sunday dinner, and somebody brings up the Occupied Territories Bill. Nobody here is a politician. Voices are raised anyway.
- **The nurses' strike.** They walk out, appointments are cancelled, and somebody has to decide who bends.
- **The viral post.** Four million views by lunchtime. By the evening news a minister is answering for it.
- **The coup.** Soldiers surround the parliament. By morning there's a new government and nobody voted for it.

What do these have in common?

- Somebody wants something somebody else doesn't want to give.
- There isn't enough of it to go around: money, respect, land, power, the right to be listened to.
- Eventually, *some* outcome happens. A decision gets made, even if that decision is “nothing changes.”

That's the core of politics: **conflict, plus collective decision-making, under scarcity.**

A working definition

Politics: *the process by which people decide, collectively, how to handle the things they disagree about: who gets what, who's bound by the outcome, and whether that outcome sticks.*

Notice what's *not* in that definition: parliaments, elections, politicians. Those are one place politics happens. They are not the only place.

Four ways people have defined it

Political scientists have argued about this for a while. Roughly:

- **The art of government** — cabinet rooms and parliaments. The narrowest definition.
- **Public affairs** — the public sphere, but nothing behind a front door.
- Compromise and consensus: a *method* of settling disagreement by negotiation rather than force.
- Power: anywhere one person or group gets another to do something they wouldn't otherwise do. The broadest definition.

Why bother defining it at all?

Because how you draw the line decides what counts as a *political* problem and what gets waved away as “just personal,” “just private,” “just the market.”

Bernard Crick's defence

“Politics [is] the activity by which differing interests within a given unit of rule are conciliated by giving them a share of power...”

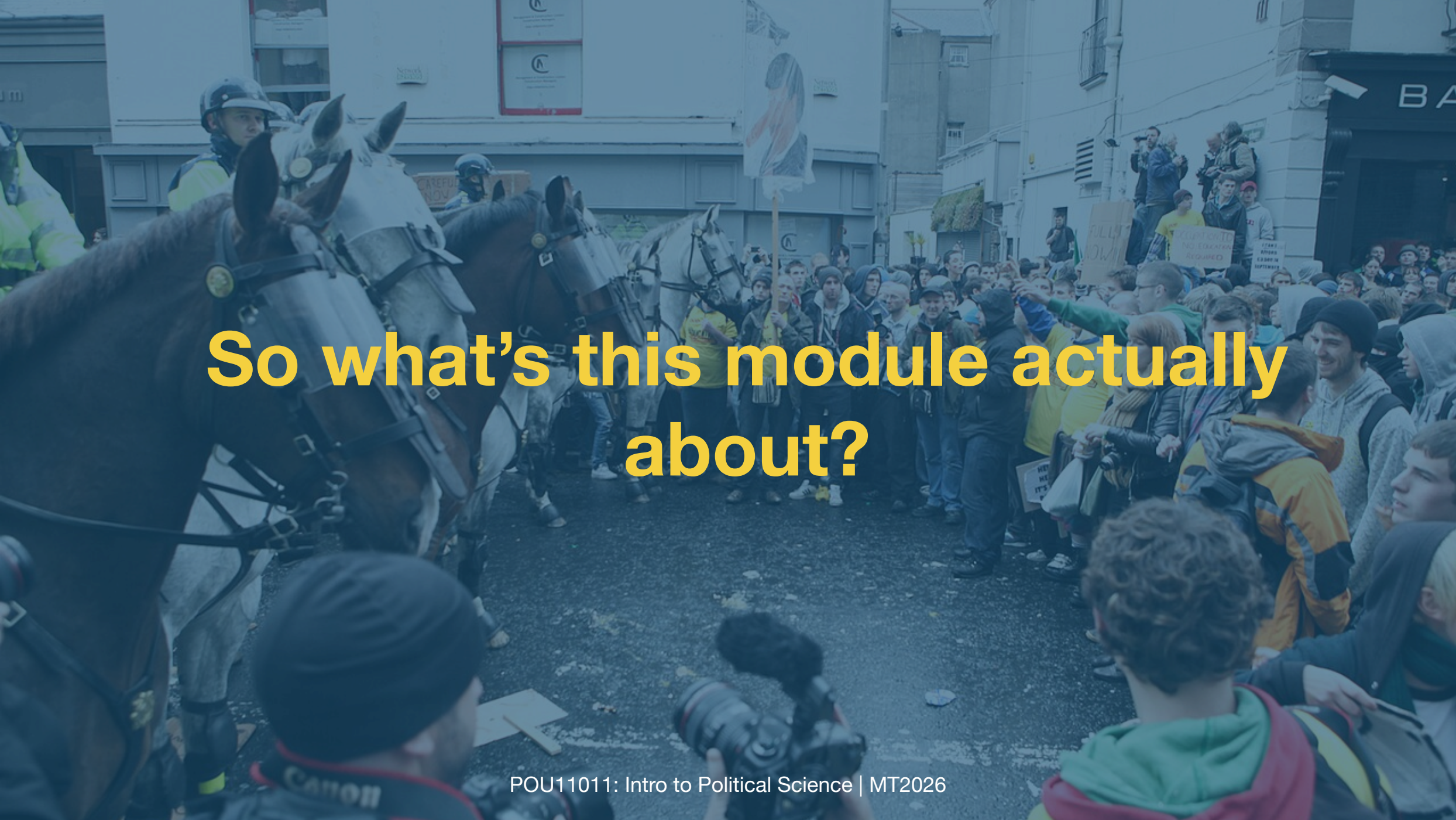
— Bernard Crick, In Defence of Politics (1962)

Crick's real point isn't the definition. It's the *defence*: politics, messy, slow, compromising, beats the alternatives.

The kicker

- Politics is **how societies solve problems** they can't solve by force or by unanimous agreement — which is most problems.
- Every case today was politics working (or straining, or breaking). None of them were an aberration.

That's the argument this module is built on. Everything from here is “so, how does that actually work?”



So what's this module actually about?

Three questions before reading week

1. **Where do states come from and why can some of them actually run a country while others can't?**
2. **What are people on the left and the right actually arguing about?**
3. **Why do a few identities become battle lines, and most never do?**

And three after it

4. **Democracy or dictatorship and would you notice the moment one turned into the other?**
5. **Who can stop whom?** Constitutions, parliaments, planning objectors: who actually holds a veto?
6. **How do we know any of this is true** and how do political scientists get fooled?

Politics vs political *science*

- **Systematic comparison**
- **Weighing evidence across cases**
- **“How do we know that?”**

Who am I?

- From Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- Lived in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Moscow before Dublin.
- My own research: Russian politics, authoritarianism, corruption. When and why mayors get arrested, why some autocracies are more corrupt than others, how ordinary people decide whether to protest.

How this module works

- Two 50-minute lectures a week per week
- Four fortnightly tutorials across the term, led by TAs
- Readings: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (2025).

How you'll be assessed

- **10% — tutorial discussion points.** A short written submission before each of the four tutorials, plus attendance at all four.
- **30% — a short assignment.** An 800-word blog post applying a course concept to a live political event.
- **60% — a final essay.** 1,500 words, end of term, your choice from a set of questions.

Next up

Read: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, Chapter 1, the sections on power and the “faces of power.”

Posted to Blackboard after class, along with the syllabus and these slides

Think about this: who has power over your daily life that you have *never once watched them exercise*?

See you Friday

See you Friday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.